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Chapter 1

Style Sales Analysis Overview



Introduction

In today's increasingly competitive markets, the availability of clearly presented and easily manipulated sales information is of paramount importance in directing the efforts of the business.

The Style Sales Analysis application enables you to produce your own views of sales information, to enable you to make comparisons and identify trends which are vital to strategic planning.

One of the great strengths of Sales Analysis is the extent to which each individual user is able to tailor the system to their own requirements without the need for any programming. This flexibility starts with the Sales History Database which is defined by the user, along with the level at which Sales History is held. The formats of enquiry are chosen by the user, and a new view of the information may be created quickly and easily without the need for data processing personnel.

Reports may be created via a simple series of prompts, and may be requested on a regular basis, or may be simple ad-hoc enquiries to answer a pressing question.

Relationship To Other Style Applications

The Sales Analysis application makes use of primary data held in the Inventory Management and Sales Order Processing applications within Style.

It is within Inventory Management that details of items are held, including data such as item type, item group, division and sub-division.

Inventory Management also contains a database of codes and descriptions, used to maintain an abbreviated code for such details as item group, or salesman, together with a meaningful description. The great benefit of the description database is that it enables a consistent and easily validated use of codes, and also provides for a meaningful description at report or enquiry time.

Customer details are held within the Sales Order Processing application, including data such as salesman, territory, and customer class.

Company Profile

As with all Style products, Sales Analysis may be used by a number of companies, each with differing requirements. A profile of each company using the system is maintained, which details such things as the name of the company and the level at which sales history is to be held.

Calendar

To maintain independence from financial or manufacturing time periods, Sales Analysis has its own calendar, which holds the dates on which sales weeks or periods end. This enables Sales Analysis to allocate each sale to the appropriate period, according to its date.

Budgets

Budgets may be defined within Sales Analysis, and have two main characteristics, a type and a format.

The type is an overall classification, such as 'Budget', 'Target' or 'Forecast'. The format describes the attribute or attributes to which the budget relates, for example, it is possible to have a 'Target' for Salesman, salesman being a possible item on the Sales History Database, or a 'Forecast' for Customer account by Item group.

Budgets are entered by Sales History Period for a type and format previously defined. Spread profiles may be used to aid the creation of budgets, allowing an annual total to be spread over the years sales periods according to a known pattern.

Sales Analysis reports enable the comparison of budgeted values with actual sales.

The Sales History Database

Fundamental to Sales Analysis is the Sales History Database, designed to enable a high level of tailoring to individual requirements, without programming changes.

When the system is installed, you are able to choose the customer and item data elements which you wish to hold on the database. In addition to the item code, customer code and sales period, you may choose six data elements relating to the Inventory Management item master, and six relating to the Sales Order Processing customer master file. Quantity, Cost and Sales Value are also held, with provision for four further values.

You may also choose to change the screen and report headings for the data elements held on the database. For example, if you use Item type, to indicate whether an item is 'made in' or 'bought out', you can change the heading to say just that. This change is then fully incorporated within the database itself, allowing full utilisation of utilities, which will print your chosen column headings.

The Sales Analysis database is held at style level rather than full product (style/colour/size/fit).

Updates And Processing

Sales History Update

Actual sales history is drawn from the Sales Order Processing invoice data. The Sales History Update function takes this data and adds it to the Sales History Database, using the calendar to determine the appropriate sales period.

This may be run as often as required, the actual frequency depending upon how up-to-date the sales history needs to be.

Sales history is maintained at style level. A full product sales history database is available for creation of your own query reports.

Sales History Refresh

Sales Analysis enables you to selectively refresh customer or item data on the database in the event of a change.

For example, if sales regions are re-organised, so that customers fall into different regions, after the customer data in Sales Order Processing has been updated, it is possible to use the Sales History Refresh function to bring the Sales History Database into line with this re-organisation, and allow analysis to show past sales to customers, within their new regions.

Periodic Updates

Whilst Sales Analysis has no pre-defined 'month-end' reports, the functions are provided to allow you to run whatever regular reporting is required.

As you create your own reports, you are prompted to specify that they are to be run on a regular basis, for example daily, or at month end. The daily, weekly, period-end, and year-end update functions select those reports you have requested, and produce them at the appropriate time.

These regular updates also maintain the current period and year, held on the Company Profile.

Enquiries

Sales Analysis provides a powerful enquiry function, which enables you to create a view of any data element on the database, analysed in terms of any other data item. The values displayed may also be chosen from the values on the database, and the time periods may be defined in a variety of different ways.

A new view may be created simply by asking for an analysis which has not previously been used, and the application will then offer to create it.

The Sales Enquiry provides you with four columns of values, chosen by means of a number of formats, created at installation time.

A format specifies the time periods to be displayed, together with the particular value to be displayed.

For example:

This period

Last period

3 periods ago

4 periods ago

Value to be shown=Sales Value.

OR:

This period

Last period

This year

Last year

Value to be shown=Quantity.

To enquire on sales history, in a chosen format, you must enter two items:

- The data element on which to enquire
- The data element by which to analyse

For example, enquire on salesman 01 by item group, would show a breakdown by item group of salesman 01's sales. The enquiry may then be advanced to show the next salesman's sales by item group, and so forth.

Options are provided to invert the display, in order to show the sales of a selected item group by all salesmen.

A bar chart function is also provided to provide a graphical representation of the data.

Reports

Sales Analysis contains report generator functions, which enable you to specify your own reports simply and quickly. You can produce summaries at several levels, for example, a report showing item sales summarised by salesman; or produce a ranking of the best selling item groups comparing one sales period with another.

A report may be created to run on a regular basis, perhaps at month-end, or a report may be used once to answer an ad-hoc enquiry.

In addition to this there are a number of standard Housekeeping type reports.

Item File Print

This provides a listing of the items defined within Inventory Management, together with their attributes chosen for inclusion on the Sales History Database.

Customer File Print

This provides a listing of the Customers defined within Sales Order Processing, together with their attributes chosen for inclusion on the Sales History Database.

Report Specification Print

This function provides a listing of the specifications of reports defined within Sales Analysis.

Sales Report

The Sales Analysis system provides functions which enable you to run an existing sales report, or to create and optionally run a new or ad-hoc report.

Such is the ease of creating a report that Sales Analysis is particularly adept at providing reports for ad-hoc queries.

A report is created using a series of prompts by means of which you specify the reports sequence, selection and content, and when the report is to be run.

The report specification may be saved, and is then available to be run regularly, or on request.

Ranking Analysis

The Ranking Analysis function within Sales Analysis is used to sequence or rank elements by the results of a summarised value, and optionally, make comparisons between one period and another.

Thus, you could for example, choose to rank salesmen by sales value, which would summarise their sales values in order. You might choose to make a comparison and compare this month's ranking with last months, to see what changes have taken place.

The ranking function may also be made to work at a second level, and rank one element within another, for example, item group, within region, showing the best selling item groups for each region.

Utilities

Sales Analysis contains a set of utility functions which are intended for use at system installation time or under certain special circumstances.

These utilities enable ease of software installation, and continued maintenance.

Pre Requisites

This section deals with the steps involved in implementing Style Sales Analysis, from the initial installation to the production of the first enquiries and reports.

Sales Analysis may be installed as an additional module within an existing Style environment, or may be part of a new installation.

The logical pre-requisites are the same in both cases.

As with other products, Sales Analysis is supported by System Manager, which must be installed first.

Sales Analysis also requires that Inventory Management and Sales Order Processing are installed. From Inventory Management it obtains details about the items which are sold and from Sales Order Processing it obtains details of customers, and invoice details representing sales. Inventory and Sales Order Processing are part of your standard Style application.

In order for Sales Analysis to extract information about sales, the item details within Inventory Management must be maintained such that the information for analysis is present, for example item group. Likewise, the customer details required for analysis must also be present within Sales Order Processing, and some invoices must have been printed.

Basic Data

Before any processing can take place within Sales Analysis, some basic details must be set up within the application.

Company Profile

A Company Profile must be created for each company which is to use the application. This contains processing details specific to each company, and also the current year and period, maintained by period-end routines.

Calendars

Sales Analysis provides information grouped by sales period, whereas invoices are created as individual dates. In order for invoices to be placed in the appropriate period, a calendar is used.

Calendars must be created before processing starts. If you choose to hold history at a weekly level, calendars should be created for both week and period for all years which you intend to process.

Sales History Time Period Selection

The information shown on the Sales Analysis enquiry is determined by the creation of formats.

These define the time periods and the values which will be shown, and must be created before any attempt is made to use the enquiry function of Sales Analysis.

A default format 1 is used by the application, and therefore, this at least must be created.

Database

Central to the Sales Analysis application is its database, which must be defined before processing is to start.

Change Initial Field Descriptions

Within Sales Analysis, data elements or fields have internal names, which cannot be altered, but also external names by which they are identified to users of the system. The Change Initial Field Descriptions function may be used to step through the data elements, and change the names or descriptions of these in order to suit a particular installation.

Define Database

The database must be created before processing can begin. You should consider the data elements which you wish to hold before you create the database.

Budgets

Within Sales Analysis you may choose to maintain budgets, and in reports, compare budgets with actual sales. You may choose to run the application without budgets initially and introduce them later. A budget is defined in terms of a budget format, and a budget type.

You may also create spread profiles, which aid budget entry, if sales fall into a known pattern.

Definition

In order to describe the data element(s) to which a budget applies, a format must be created. This also determines the kind of value to be held, for example, cost value or sales value.

The Budget format function should be used to create the formats you require.

Spread Profiles

The Spread Profiles function enables you to define the pattern of sales over a year, by period. A number of profiles may be created and used to aid budget entry.

Budget Entry

Budgets may be entered for a year, against the data elements defined by the budget format, for the values also specified by the format.

Spread profiles may be used to spread an annual total over all the periods in a year.

Sales History

Sales history enables invoice analysis and the creation of enquiry, reporting and updating functions based upon those data elements that are relevant to your needs. For more information see:

- Invoices
- Updating Sales Analysis
- Enquiry
- Reporting

Invoices

Sales Analysis draws its information on sales from data within Sales Order Processing. For processing to start, invoices must have been printed within Sales Order Processing.

Updating Sales Analysis

The Sales History Update function takes printed invoice data and posts the information to the Sales History Database. Once posted, the invoices are marked as such and will not be included in subsequent updates. If large volumes of data are involved this function may take some time to complete.

Enquiry

The Sales Enquiry function will prompt you to enter a data element on which to enquire, and to select a data element by which to analyse. The first time a new enquiry combination is selected, the system will build summary data but there after the enquiry will be performed straight away.

Reporting

Sales Analysis enables you to create your own Sales Reports and Ranking Analysis Reports.

The Reports Specifications and Ranking Analysis Specification functions allow you to define reports quickly and easily. They may be created and run as part of the specification maintenance, or they may be selected by name at a later time, or included in the regular update runs.

Miscellaneous

For more information regarding Sales Analysis file library details and Enquiry bar chart characters see:

- [Library For User Created Objects](#)
- [Bar Chart Characters And Colours](#)

Library For User Created Objects

Sales Analysis creates the system program and file objects during its execution. These must be directed to a specific library. A data area called SAUSRLIB contains the name of the library in which these objects will be placed. The default supplied by the system will be the Sales Analysis file library.

Bar Chart Characters And Colours

The characters to be used in the Enquiry bar chart are contained in the data area SABARCHARS, in hexadecimal form, and the display attributes are held in the data area SABARCHCOL. These both contain default values, which you may change to tailor the bar chart display.